{WP} The Mural - Prose Sample

“Brother Pierre, do you see this?" Ronen asked the prior, his face pale as a leper’s against the rapturous skies.

Even without looking at what he had to show, Pierre knew what it was. Every young novice discovered it when they first entered the hall, much to similar shock and foreboding.

Prior Pierre didn't know who had commissioned the art work - it was old - but it had become a sort of a soft tradition at the abbey. It was the mural painted in the refectory above the trestle tables. It was colored in grave darks and blood reds and had illustrated dancing devils roasting a cross over spit fire as men, women and beast with equal grins and malicious visages danced around it.

It was to be noticed, to be reported, to elicit fear in the minds of the young. It was a test, though perhaps not an intentional one.

However, the prior felt that the mural drew more shock than any meaningful exegesis. Having spent several years in the service of the clergy as outriding missionary and an observer monk, brother Pierre had naturally witnessed many more visceral sights than this and had even partaken in them. Even as a test, it felt weak and gratuitous rather than anything useful.

The Devil is more subtle, boy.

"I see it, novice Ronen. What are you going to do about this?", Pierre asked as he poured some wine into his cup.

There was no answer from the novice, the boy stood at the mural's precipice, spellbound with his mouth slightly ajar with the continued shock.

The silence was somewhat warranted, especially of children raised under Benedictine doctrine. Pierre certainly wasn't a fan of it, but he let the boy indulge in his emotions.

Send them out in the world, let them know the trueness of this world's evils rather than feeding them with binary dogma.

"H-how... bb- this- ", Ronen finally manage to squeak a few half-gibbered words out after an indeterminable silence.

Before the prior could laugh and make a joke of it and guide him true, the young novice had already fetched a dirty rag from the corner of the room - where brother Jurgen had left the custodial equipment - and begun to rub the ancient mural into the next life.

The boy's fervor in removing the devil from their refectory had started to become unnerving.

"What are you doing?"

"Getting rid of this profane work!" the boy shouted with less than a kind tone.

"It's a mural."

"You aren't defeating the devil today", Pierre said as he took another sip from his cup, "but I appreciate your enthusiasm."

"Now come down, we have a lot to discuss."